Q&A Drills

Core skills trio, part 2 of 3 · Defence: how the argument survives questioning. The other two: `presentation_and_storyline_guide.md` · `business_math_drills.md`. Folder overview: `README.md`.

Q&A is scored in every Asper round — 15 minutes after the Prepared case, 10 minutes after the Traditional case, and the 22-minute Boardroom discussion, which is effectively all Q&A. Coaches across competitions describe Q&A as the tiebreaker between closely ranked teams. Asper's judges are practitioners: they probe assumptions, feasibility, and ownership. Our standard: every answer inside 30 seconds, answer first, with a number.

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1. The answer-first protocol

Every answer follows **P-A-B-S**:

1. **Pause** (1–2 seconds). Breathe. It signals thought, buys composure, and guarantees the judge has finished speaking.
2. **Answer** in the first sentence. Direct: "Yes, with one condition." / "2.1 years." / "We assumed 8 percent, and here is why."
3. **Because** — one or two supporting points, at least one number, ideally a slide or appendix reference.
4. **Stop.** Land the last word and hold the silence. No trailing off, no third reason.

Timing: 20–30 seconds standard; 45 seconds maximum for a financial walk-through with an appendix slide on screen.

When we don't know: never bluff. Script: "We haven't calculated that precisely. Based on [case anchor], our estimate is [X]. It is the first thing we would validate in the pilot's 30-day review." An honest gap plus an instant estimate plus a validation plan scores; improvised fiction dies on the follow-up question.

Hard rules: never contradict a teammate in front of judges — add nuance instead ("One addition —"); never argue with a judge — re-ground the discussion in the facts we presented; ask for clarification of a fuzzy question before answering it; when a judge starts nodding, wrap up and invite the next question.

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2. Bridging technique

Bridging returns any question to prepared ground in three moves: **Acknowledge → Bridge → Anchor.**

Move	Phrase bank
Acknowledge	"Fair challenge." / "That is exactly the right question on this slide." / "You're right — that is the sensitive assumption."
Bridge	"And that is why…" / "What the case data tells us is…" / "The way we protected against that is…"
Anchor	…a prepared strength: a sensitivity table, a phasing gate, an appendix slide, the governing thesis.

Example: *"Isn't this too expensive for a mid-sized client?"* → "Fair — cash is the constraint. That is why the plan self-funds after month nine: Phase 1 needs only CAD 400k, and Phase 2 is paid from Phase 1 margin. Appendix 6 shows the cash curve."

Bridging is for steering, not evasion: the Answer step always comes first. A dodge that skips the answer is instantly visible to practitioner judges.

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3. The Q&A quarterback system

One member — the Quarterback (our PM) — runs traffic. Nobody else decides who answers.

- **Routing.** Domain questions go to their owner by name: "Our numbers are Lena's — Lena?" Ambiguous or hostile questions: the Quarterback takes first contact, answers or reframes, then routes.
- **Ownership map.** Chief Analyst: all financials and assumptions. Strategist: market, competition, alternatives ("why not X?"). Design & Data Lead: customer, data, technology, operations detail. Quarterback: prompt scope, prioritization, implementation, anything political.
- **One voice per answer.** A second member may add exactly one sentence, and only if it adds new value. Pile-ons are banned.
- **Coverage tracking.** The Quarterback tracks airtime — in boardroom formats a silent member can sink the team — and steers questions toward anyone running light: "Max built that analysis — Max?"
- **Rescue protocol.** If a teammate stalls: no correction, no rescue-grab. The Quarterback bridges — "Let me add the context behind Lena's point —" — gives the teammate two seconds to recover, then hands back if possible.
- **The DJ.** The Design & Data Lead pulls numbered appendix slides on demand; every financial answer should land with its exhibit on screen within five seconds.
- **The close.** If the moderator allows, the Quarterback ends Q&A with a 20-second recap of recommendation and impact — the last words the judges hear are ours.

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4. Drill formats

- **Rapid fire (10 min):** the coach fires questions from the banks below at 30-second intervals; any answer over 30 seconds or without a number is repeated.
- **Red team:** alumni or the coach play hostile board members after every practice case — alumni calibrate best to real judge intensity.
- **Distraction drill:** answer while a teammate rustles paper or a timer beeps mid-sentence; composure is trainable.
- **The 10-hardball set,** pre-written before every presentation: biggest assumption risk; the recommendation at half the projected market growth; "why not just cut costs?"; competitor response; feasibility; market-size validation; timeline and resources; stakeholder buy-in; comparison to rejected alternatives; funding source.
- **Film review:** record every mock Q&A; review for answer-first discipline, pace, and fillers.

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5. Question banks — 60 hard questions

Model answer patterns follow the first three questions of each group; drill the rest against the same patterns.

A. Financial challenge

1. Your projection assumes 8% growth; the case says the market grows 3%. Reconcile that.
2. What is the payback period — and what happens if it doubles?
3. Your CAC number looks invented. Where does it come from?
4. Halve your Year-1 volume. Does the recommendation survive?
5. Why a 10% discount rate — and what happens at 15%?
6. Your margin improves five points. Which cost lines, exactly?
7. How is this funded, and what does it do to cash and covenants?
8. What is the write-off if the pilot fails after Phase 1?
9. Your break-even requires 30% segment share. Realistic?
10. Which numbers are from the case, and which did you invent?
11. How much of the new revenue cannibalizes the existing line?
12. You are recommending CAD spending with EUR thinking. Where is the FX risk?

Model 1: "The market grows 3%; our 8% is that 3% plus five points of share gain from the two channels on slide 9. If we win zero share and only ride the market, NPV falls from 4.1M to 1.9M — still positive. The

decision survives our own worst case." *(Pattern: decompose the number; show the floor still clears.)*

Model 2: "2.1 years. If it doubles to 4.2, the project still beats the client's hurdle rate but ties up cash longer — which is exactly why month 18 is a hard go/no-go gate: we scale only on evidence." *(Pattern: number instantly, then the built-in control.)*

Model 3: "It is an assumption, derived from the case: marketing spend of 600k historically produced 12,000 new customers — CAD 50 per customer. We stressed it to double; the plan holds until CAC 110. Appendix 7." *(Pattern: own the assumption, derive it from case data, show the sensitivity.)*

B. Feasibility attack

13. Your timeline is 12 months; this client has never executed anything in under 24. Why will this work?
14. Who exactly implements this? Show me the headcount.
15. The client's legacy IT cannot support this.
16. The retail partners will refuse those terms. Then what?
17. This needs capabilities the client lacks. Build, buy, or partner — and why yours?
18. What breaks first when you scale this?
19. How do you get the works council or union on board?
20. The pilot succeeds. Walk me through the next 90 days, week by week.
21. Regulatory approval alone eats your entire launch window.
22. Why hasn't management already done this obvious thing?
23. Your plan depends on a single supplier. What if they fail?
24. The budget is cut 40% tomorrow. What do you drop?

Model 13: "We planned against their track record, not the best case. The 12 months covers only a one-region pilot using existing staff; national rollout is months 12 to 24. The critical path is IT integration — which is why it starts in week one." *(Pattern: shrink the claim to what fits the window; name the critical path.)*

Model 14: "Five people: three redeployed FTEs plus two hires — a product owner and a data engineer, with recruiting starting day one. The vendor's onboarding team bridges the gap. Costed at 380k in Year 1, slide 12." *(Pattern: named roles, counted heads, costed.)*

Model 15: "We assumed no core-system replacement — the solution sits as an API layer on the platform the case says was upgraded last year. If integration proves harder, the fallback is the vendor-hosted version at two points lower margin. Appendix 9." *(Pattern: an architecture answer plus a costed fallback.)*

C. Ethics and risk

25. You are pushing premium prices onto the customers who can least afford them.
26. You monetize customer data. GDPR and PIPEDA — show me compliance.
27. Your plan implies layoffs. How do you handle the people?
28. Isn't your sustainability angle just greenwashing?
29. What is the single biggest risk, and what triggers an abort?
30. If this partnership fails publicly, what happens to the brand?
31. Your AI feature — bias and transparency?
32. How confident are you, honestly? Give me a range, not a point estimate.
33. Your low-cost sourcing: who audits supplier labor standards?
34. Who loses in your plan — and did you account for them?
35. Where are environmental compliance costs in your P&L?
36. A competitor copies this in six months. Was the money wasted?

Model 25: "Affordability was a design constraint, not an afterthought: the entry product stays at today's price, so nobody is priced out — premiumization targets the gifting segment, which the case shows holds 70% of value. Net of that guardrail, margin still gains three points." *(Pattern: show the safeguard was designed in; quantify net of it.)*

Model 26: "Everything runs on first-party, opt-in data — a consent-first design that satisfies both GDPR and Canada's PIPEDA. We budgeted 150k for privacy engineering and a data-protection impact assessment before launch; it is a line in the implementation plan, not a footnote." *(Pattern: name the regime; show it costed and scheduled.)*

Model 27: "Redeployment first: twelve roles change, eight people are retrained into the new service team,

natural attrition covers the rest, and severance is provisioned at 200k. We involve employee representatives from week one, because adoption depends on trust." *(Pattern: humane, specific, provisioned.)*

D. Curveball

37. Your budget is zero. How do you still move the needle?
38. Same case, but a family business. What changes?
39. Sell me your recommendation in one sentence.
40. What is the weakest part of your own plan?
41. The CEO rejects your recommendation. What is Plan B?
42. A recession starts next quarter. What changes?
43. Which single KPI would you accept your own bonus on?
44. Thirty seconds in an elevator with the most skeptical director. Go.
45. What did you not have time to analyze?
46. Would you invest your own money in this? How much?
47. A competitor launches the identical product tomorrow morning.
48. What question were you hoping we would not ask?

Model 37: "Two of our moves need no capital: pricing discipline and the referral loop — together roughly 40% of the impact, using assets the client already owns. The investment buys the remaining 60%, and the speed." *(Pattern: separate process moves from capital moves.)*

Model 38: "The strategy holds; the pacing changes. Longer horizon, the founder's original line stays untouched to protect the family brand, and we fund from cash flow instead of debt to preserve control." *(Pattern: same destination, adjusted governance.)*

Model 39: "[Client] should [action], because it converts [existing asset] into [quantified outcome] within [timeframe], with downside capped by [gate]." *(Pattern: pre-write this sentence for every case — it also opens the boardroom pitch.)*

E. Hostile

49. The last consultants recommended exactly this. It failed. Why repeat it?
50. Your numbers are simply wrong.
51. You clearly don't understand this industry.
52. That is the most generic recommendation we have heard today.
53. You ignored the prompt. We asked about X.
54. Your teammate just said the opposite. Which of you is right?
55. I stopped listening at slide three. Why should I care?
56. This might work in Germany. It will never work here.
57. You are telling us what we want to hear.
58. A pilot is just a way to avoid making a real decision, isn't it?
59. (The judge interrupts every answer mid-sentence.)
60. Why should we trust four students with a 50-million decision?

Model 49: "That history shaped our plan. The earlier attempt failed in execution — the case cites X. Our version differs in exactly the two places it broke: [a] and [b]. Same destination, different engine." *(Pattern: agree with the history; differentiate on mechanism.)*

Model 50: Pause, stay warm, invite specificity: "Happy to walk through them — which figure shall we start with?" Then re-derive that one figure from case data with the appendix slide up. *(Pattern: never defend in general; force one number, win that number.)*

Model 51: "You know this industry far better than we do — so let us show what we anchored on: three facts from the case, [1], [2], [3]. If any of those contradicts your experience, we would genuinely like to hear it; it would change our sizing, not the core logic." *(Pattern: humility, invite the expertise, protect the core.)*

House rules under fire: voice low and slow; the smile stays professional, never smug; hostility is a composure test, not an information request — judges are watching how we treat each other and them. We never argue, never sulk, never fold: acknowledge, answer, anchor.